

Cybercrime Case Study

The "Scanner" Trap

The Incident: A Costly Mistake

Aryan, a second-year college student, decided to sell his old Kindle so that he could get some extra money for his semester books. He posted an advertisement on a second-hand marketplace, hoping to find a buyer soon. After some time, he received a message from a person named Vikram who seemed very interested in buying the Kindle.

Vikram told Aryan that he was an Army officer and needed the item urgently. He also said that he would make the payment immediately to confirm the deal. Since everything was happening quickly, Aryan didn't think too much about it and agreed.

Vikram then sent a QR code on WhatsApp and asked Aryan to scan it and enter his UPI PIN so that the payment could be transferred. Aryan followed the instructions without realizing something was wrong. Instead of receiving money, ₹18,500 was deducted from his account. By the time Aryan understood what had happened, Vikram had already blocked him and disappeared.

The Aftermath & Identity Risks

This incident did not only result in financial loss, but it also exposed Aryan's personal details. Since he had shared his mobile number and UPI ID, there was a risk that these details could be misused later for other types of scams like phishing or fake calls.

Lessons Learned & Prevention

- The UPI PIN is only used when sending money. It should never be entered to receive money.
- It is important not to make decisions in a hurry, especially in online transactions.
- Personal information such as Aadhaar, PAN, or bank details should not be shared with unknown people.
- In case of any cyber fraud, immediate action should be taken by calling the cybercrime helpline (1930), as early reporting can help in reducing the loss.